

THE TEST VOYAGE

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A Pipeline Validation

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First edition

Set in Georgia.

For everyone who ever lost a Saturday to a KDP margin.

The night was young.

— the last line, always

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CHAPTER ONE — DEPARTURE



The harbor was still dark when the ship slipped her moorings. No band played, no crowd waved from the quay; there was only the low working of the tide against the stone and the creak of rope taking strain. She went out past the breakwater the way a thought leaves a sleeping mind, without announcement, and the town behind her folded itself back into the fog.

On deck a single lantern burned. It threw a circle of yellow light that moved with the swell, and inside that circle a man stood with his hands on the rail and watched the last of the land go under the horizon. He had made this crossing before, in other years, in other weather, and he knew that the first hour was the hardest — the hour when the shore was gone and the far side was still only a rumor, a name on a chart, a promise no one had signed.

The wind freshened out of the northwest. The sails filled and hardened and the ship leaned into her work, and the water that had been black grew a long pale seam along the hull where the bow tore it open. He listened to that sound for a while. It was the only conversation the sea offered, and it never repeated itself.

By the time the sky began to gray in the east the coast was nothing at all, not even a shadow, and the man went below to sleep while he still could. The voyage had begun. Whatever it was going to cost, it had started charging.

CHAPTER TWO — THE CROSSING



For six days the ship held her heading and the sea did not change its mind. It was the middle passage, the long featureless middle that no one writes songs about, where every horizon is the same horizon and the only proof of motion is the log line paying out astern. The crew fell into the rhythm of it — watch and sleep, watch and sleep — and the days lost their edges and ran together like ink in water.

The man kept a small notebook. He was not a writer by trade, but there is a kind of solitude at sea that presses on a person until something has to come out of them, and for him it came out as sentences. He wrote about the color of the water at noon, which was not blue and not green but some third thing the language had never bothered to name. He wrote about the way the stars at night seemed close enough to foul the rigging. He wrote, once, a single line and then closed the book quickly, as if he had said too much.

On the fifth night the wind died altogether and the ship lay becalmed on a sea like black glass. The sails hung slack. The lantern's reflection stood upside down in the water, perfectly still, a second small fire burning in the deep. He leaned over the rail and looked at it for a long time. It was very quiet. It was the kind

of quiet that makes a person understand, all at once and without wanting to, exactly how far from everything they have come.

Then, near dawn, the wind returned. The sails woke. The ship gathered herself and went on, and the far side of the water, which had been only a rumor, began at last to become a fact.

CHAPTER THREE — LANDFALL



Land showed first as a smudge that might have been a cloud, low on the western rim, and the man did not trust it until it refused to move for a full hour. Then he trusted it. A coastline has a patience that weather does not. It simply waits, and grows, and becomes undeniable.

By afternoon he could see the shape of hills, and then the pale scatter of a town along a shore, and then the individual houses, white and small and ordinary, the astonishing ordinariness of a place that has been going on the whole time without him. Smoke rose from a chimney. A road ran along the water. Somewhere a bell was ringing, thin across the distance, and it was the first sound in seven days that the sea had not made.

The ship came in on the evening tide. The man stood again at the rail, in the same place he had stood at the beginning, and watched the new land assemble itself out of the light. He had crossed. Whatever he had been at the far harbor, he was not quite that now; the middle passage takes something and leaves something, and no one gets to choose the exchange rate.

He put the notebook in his coat. The lantern was lit against the coming dark, though the dark had not quite come. There was

still a band of gold along the hilltops and a warmth in the air off the shore, and the whole town lay open in front of him, unhurried, unfinished, waiting to be walked into. The night was young.

